How I approach buyer research for an SME sale

A worked example of my method · Axel Pettersson · October 2026

About the example: the company, Tallmora Plåtteknik AB, is fictional. Its name, history and figures are invented to illustrate the method. The buyers and deals named are real and come from public sources.

The method: research runs in parallel, decisions are mine

1 — Me

Understand the company

Ownership first, then the numbers and why they move

2 — Me

Write the search brief

Buyer groups, size, geography and scoring, before any names

3 — AI, from my brief

Collect buyers and deals

Four research tracks run at the same time, every name with a source

4 — Me

Screen on buyers' criteria

Cut anyone the company clearly doesn't fit, with a written reason

5 — Me + Excel

Score and prioritise

Four criteria, 1–3 points each; totals as formulas in Excel

6 — Me

Check by hand

Facts behind the shortlist checked against the original pages

Orange = my judgement · grey = AI-assisted research. About one working day with public sources only.

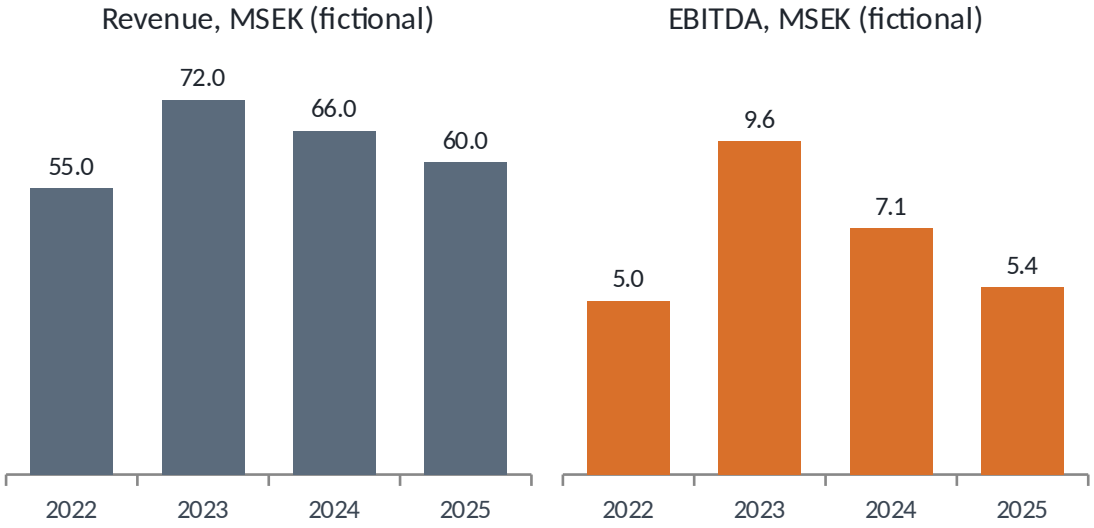
Fictional example company. Buyers and deals named are real and taken from public sources.

Step 1: understand the company before looking for buyers

~35 employees, family-owned, based in Småland

2 lines: contract sheet metal and steel for construction

~6.8 MSEK average EBITDA 2022–25



What I look for first

Who owns it: a company already in a group has no owner to sell for. Then why the numbers moved, from the annual report's own explanation.

In the example, 2023 was lifted by a one-off order. A buyer will value the business on a normal year, so I work with average earnings over the cycle, not the peak. That single number decides which buyers are realistic.

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Step 2: write the search brief before any names

Field	What I decide	In this example
Buyer groups	Which kinds of buyer to include	Same-industry buyers, adjacent buyers (customers, distributors), foreign groups, financial owners
Geography	Where the search starts	Sweden and the Nordics first, then wider
Size	Deal sizes the buyer should have done	Targets of roughly 20–80 MSEK revenue
Evidence of fit	What counts as proof	A past acquisition of a similar company, or the buyer's published criteria
Scoring	How candidates are ranked	Four criteria, 1–3 points each, equal weights

Why first

If the criteria are set after the names are found, they tend to bend to fit those names. Writing them down first keeps the screen honest.

The same brief goes, word for word, into every research track in step 3, so the results can be merged later.

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Step 3: collect buyers and deals in four parallel tracks

1 Market

What drives demand: construction outlook, grid investment, labour supply

2 Industry buyers

Same-industry and adjacent buyers, each with a past deal as evidence

3 Financial buyers

PE platforms, holding companies, individual buyers, with published criteria

4 Deal history

Comparable sales 2021–26: who bought, what, at what size

How I use AI here

- I write one brief with the facts I've verified, a fixed output table and one rule: every name needs a link to the page it came from
- Claude runs the four tracks at the same time
- I merge the results and remove duplicates; the same buyer often turns up in three tracks

Sources: public only

- Annual reports and public company registers
- Press releases from listed buyers (MFN, Cision)
- Buyers' own websites and published acquisition criteria
- Advisors' public deal announcements and business press
- No paid databases

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The deal history adds names and shows who actually buys

Year	Target	Size	Buyer	Buyer type
2022	GAJ Stålkonstruktioner	~57 MSEK	Fasadgruppen	Listed consolidator
2024	JE:s Svets & Smide	~31 MSEK	Fasadgruppen (via GAJ)	Add-on
2023	B-Max Svets	~35 MSEK	Ahlsell	Distributor
2023	Laserkraft Bredaryd	not shown	PVI Industries	Industrial group
2024	JIT Mech	~130 MSEK	AQ Group	Contract manufacturer
2026	Bjärnums Stålprodukter	not disclosed	SBF Invest + key staff	Individuals with management

30–150 MSEK

typical disclosed target size

Consolidators

the most active buyer group

New buyer types

distributors and individuals buying

I read deals for patterns, not just names. Prices are rarely disclosed at this size, so I don't value the company from them.

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Step 4: screen on each buyer's own criteria



Why a buyer was cut	Examples
Only buys companies with their own products	Lagercrantz, Indutrade, Addtech
Earnings floor above the target's	Bergman & Beving; Storskogen at group level
Recent deals many times larger	HANZA, Latour
Prefers asset-light businesses	Röko

14 of 38 cut, each with a written reason. The best-known serial acquirers are often the wrong buyers for a company this size, and their own published criteria say so.

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Step 5: score and prioritise, then check by hand

Criterion	3 points	1 point
Business fit	Buys companies doing the same work	Weak link
Size fit	Has bought companies this size	Deals mostly far larger
Track record	Several comparable deals since 2021	None, or old
Geography	Existing unit in the region	No Swedish link

Scores are inputs; totals and priority are formulas, so changing one score re-ranks the list. Priority A = 9+ of 12.

Priority A	Pts	Evidence (public)
Fasadgruppen	**11**	Three steel and sheet-metal deals since 2022
Opima (Celero)	**11**	13 workshop acquisitions since late 2024
Ahlsell	**9**	Bought steel-structure maker B-Max Svets
Söderbergföretagen	**9**	Owns sheet-metal maker Henjo in Småland
Weland	**9**	Sheet metal, stairs, railings; Småland
PVI Industries	**9**	Bought Laserkraft Bredaryd in 2023

Checked by hand: the deal behind every A-list buyer, against the original page. Known weakness: equal weights leave seven buyers tied at 8 points, so the B list needs a second look rather than a mechanical cut-off.

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Keeping it checkable, and where the method applies

How I keep the work checkable

- Every number and every buyer has a source link
- Unknowns stay as open questions, not estimates
- The workbook is built and checked with a Python script, so formulas and ranges are consistent
- AI collects; I set the criteria, weights and cuts, and check the shortlist myself

M&A advisors	A sourced, prioritised buyer list for a sale
Private equity	The same steps, mirrored: screening add-on targets for a platform
Corporate development	Screening acquisition targets against a stated strategy
Analytics roles	Turning messy public information into a structured, scored dataset

Limits: public sources only, so no deal prices, customer data or order backlog. With access to paid deal databases I'd fill gaps in the deal history and confirm contacts.

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